

divorce. The Qur'an reveres several women. Unlike in the Hebrew bible, Eve is described as Adam's mate and helper—she is not created from his rib, but, like Adam, is one half of a single soul that was split into two. Other notable females recognized by the Qur'an are Asiya, the pious wife of the tyrannical Pharaoh in the time of Moses; Mary, mother of Jesus; and Fatima, the daughter of the Prophet.

The Prophet is recorded in both early Sunni and Shia Arabic sources as having shown a particularly high degree of respect for his daughter. Fatima, known as the “Shining One” is praised in both the Qur'an and *hadith*

(records of the Prophet's words and actions) for her purity and devotion to her father and faith. Today, Muslims continued to honor Fatima and her descendants—such as her daughter, Zainab, who played an active role in teaching women the new religion, traveling widely in the Islamic world with her male relatives. Zainab was also a witness to the defeat and martyrdom in 681 CE of her brother Husain at the battle of Karbala, after which she was imprisoned by the victors. The Qur'an encourages women to emulate the Prophet's female descendants, such as Fatima and Zainab, in faith and works.

BIOGRAPHY

KHADĪJA BINT KHUWAYLID

Khadīja was the first wife of the Prophet Muhammad. Muhammad often described her as the love of his life. She was the mother of his beloved daughter Fatima. Khadīja was not only slightly older than Muhammad but she was also his employer. Historical sources confirm that her wealth surpassed that of any male trader in the Arabian Peninsula. In the years when the pagans imposed sanctions on the Muslims, it was her wealth that saved them.

◀ **Guardian of the Qur'an**

Initially recited from memory, the teachings of the Qur'an were written down in the 650s to be preserved and distributed. Some scholars suggest that Hafsa bint 'Umar—one of the Prophets' wives—acted as its first editor, and as a guardian of the original documents. This manuscript was created in Morocco in the 12th century.